



AS BANERJEE (LEFT) GAINS MASS SUPPORT, BHATTACHARYA IS LOSING INDUSTRIALISTS' BACKING

for her adversary. Since she became the Railways Minister, there has not been a single day in Bengal when Banerjee has not flagged off a new train or laid the foundation stone for, say, a railway hospital project.

Everybody in the Banerjee wave forgets that between 1991 and 2008, the state got industrial approval for 5,048 projects and even if 10 per cent of these have been implemented, for an industry-starved state like Bengal, it could be good news. Commerce Secretary Sabyasachi Sen said, "A one-third conversion is going great guns. I can't find fault with the figures as in achievements of the Government. However, an approval is not the end of a project; it is just an act of intent. There are many other steps to go through before work can start." For the Left, these words could be prophetic. For now, it does not even have the approval and in the next two years, by the look of things, is unlikely to gain any from those who will decide who will reach the post first. By all indications, the people have made up their mind. And there does not seem to be anything now that brings cheers to the comrades.

"I have never met Mamata personally. But I think she has her heart in the right place."

The party is now seen by all, except its own leaders, as a heartless, corrupt ruling demon while Banerjee, despite her pendulum-like temperament, soars in popularity. The Left's main plank of agrarian reforms has been totally usurped by the Banerjee magic. The Left has become a party for the middle class, by the middle class and of the middle class. Bhattacharya looks and acts like the typical representative of the middle class urban segment aspiring for the high life (read industry), which his illustrious predecessors had studiously avoided. You cannot afford to write poetry and woo industrialists at the cost of agricultural land and the peasants if you are the Left. That was Bhattacharya's cardinal mistake on which Banerjee sowed her seeds of victory.

To worsen the Front's problems, top industrialists, a segment that Bhattacharya assiduously wooed till the fall of Singur and Nano, seem to be leaving him, some even making a beeline for Banerjee's camp. West Bengal is also tottering at its base with criminalisation of politics which had never been the case. Ratan Khasnabis, economist and social historian, says, "Criminalisation is the automatic fallout of illegal money flowing to the grassroots. Small-time leaders held sway in the rural pockets and grew in political, and by consequence, social status. This has led to the creation of Frankenssteins in the village backyard."

In a state which has 26 per cent Muslims, Banerjee has played the minorities card well. The total vote share of the CPI(M) in West Bengal has fallen from 38.6 per cent to 31.1 per cent while Trinamool's has risen to a whopping 31 per cent from 21 per cent. Unfortunately for the state Government, it has been Banerjee again who has usurped even the last vestiges of honour and accolades left

KERALA

The Lost Slogan

Armed Dalits are the new revolutionaries

| By M.G. Radhakrishnan |

The Chengara agitation was unusual in many ways. On August 4, 2007, more than 3,000 families—mostly Dalit—forcibly entered a privately-owned rubber estate near Chengara in Pathanamthitta, set up tents and refused to move out until they were given cultivable plot of five acres each. All attempts by the court, the state Government and the police for more than two years to evict them from the RPG Enterprises Group's Harrison Malayalam Plantations Ltd-owned estate came to naught as they threatened to commit mass suicide if forcibly removed. The agitators, armed with only sticks and domestic tools, barred entry of all outsiders and lived there for a record 789 days. This October 5, the agitation was called off after the state Government promised in writing that it would distribute different extents of land and money to build houses